PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Chevrolet/GMC Suburban (1973–1991 square body)

1973–1991 · K10 · K20 · V1500 · V2500

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Rust: rockers, floors and wheel wells**
  Hagerty names these as the main problem areas, especially on early trucks. Also check the bottoms of all four doors and the rear doors or tailgate, and look under the carpet. Mill Supply and Auto Metal Direct sell the panels, but a structurally rotten 'Burb is a big job.

- [ ] **Frame at the steering box**
  Hagerty says lifted 4×4s on bigger tires need frame bracing at the steering box or cracking is likely. Offroad Design calls frame cracks there notorious on straight-axle GM trucks. Look for cracks, fresh welds or a brace that's already been fitted.

- [ ] **Is it really a 4×4, and which case?**
  Look for a front driveshaft and a V or K in the model badging. BaT has sold a C2500 with a 4×4 swap. Then identify the case: the NP203 (full-time, 1973–79) is long and in four sections, the NP205 is one piece of iron, and the NP208 is aluminum.

- [ ] **Hubs on 1981-and-later trucks**
  From 1981 GM fitted automatic locking hubs with the NP208, and manual hubs were optional. Make sure the front engages in 4WD and frees up in 2WD. Many owners have already swapped to manual hubs.

- [ ] **Check rear HVAC and the dash**
  Hagerty notes that the Suburban-only rear heater and air-conditioning parts can be hard to fix, and that dash pads often crack down the center. Run both front and rear air and heat before you buy.

- [ ] **Rear window and tailgate**
  Wikipedia notes that the wind-down rear glass is heavy, that hand-crank gears and electric motors wear, and that a drive cable links the motor to the regulator. A safety switch stops the glass rising if the tailgate isn't latched, so check that the tailgate is latched before you blame the motor.

- [ ] **Check modifications carefully**
  Hagerty's advice is to inspect any modifications carefully. Lifts, engine swaps and wiring jobs vary widely in quality. A stock, rust-free V1500 often makes a better starting point than someone else's half-finished build.

- [ ] **6.2 diesel trucks**
  Wikipedia lists crankshaft failures related to age-worn harmonic balancers, plus main-bearing web cracks, as known 6.2/6.5 problems. Ask about the balancer and listen for knocks. A diesel is slow, but it gives you range.

YEARS TO KNOW

1987	SWEET SPOT	Throttle-body fuel injection on all gasoline engines. C/K renamed R/V (R = 2WD, V = 4×4). Owners on GMSquareBody and CK5 point to the TBI trucks for better mileage, more

power and reliability than the carbureted ones

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Brake pedal push-rod retainer clip may be missing**
  1981 · NHTSA 80V150000
- ☐ **Platform trailer-hitch bolts under-torqued**
  1982 · NHTSA 82V028000
- ☐ **Driver's seat belt may not lock**
  1988 · NHTSA 89V010000
- ☐ **Transmission fluid forced out of the vent**
  1988–1991 · NHTSA 93V016000
- ☐ **Front brake rotor separation from road-salt corrosion**
  1988–1991 (Chevrolet) · NHTSA 93V119000
- ☐ **Seat recliner bolts may loosen**
  1989–1990 · NHTSA 93V187000
- ☐ **Seat recliner bolts may loosen**
  1991 · NHTSA 96V226000
- ☐ **Certain FRAM G3727 replacement fuel filters**
  1987–1991 (fitment) · NHTSA 06E043000

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **Year by front end**
  Per Hagerty: 1973–80 trucks have round headlamps, a styled hood and vertical side markers; 1981–88 trucks have rectangular lamps, a flat hood and horizontal markers; 1989–91 trucks have four small rectangular headlamps (two on economy trims, per Wikipedia).
- ☐ **Model codes**
  C = 2WD and K = 4×4, with 10/20 for Chevrolet half- and three-quarter-ton and 15/25 for GMC until 1980. For 1987–91 the trucks are R (2WD) and V (4×4), badged 1500/2500.
- ☐ **True 4×4 or conversion?**
  Check for a factory front axle, transfer case and K/V designation. BaT has sold a C2500 Suburban with a 4×4 swap. Also, no factory 4×4 Suburban had a 454 per Chevrolet's 1982 and 1987 spec sheets.
- ☐ **Transfer case**
  NP203 (full-time, 1973–79): about 22–23 in long, four bolted sections, with a lock position. NP205: one-piece iron case, three-bolt idler cover, tag above the front output. NP208 (1981+): aluminum, chain-drive (Offroad Design, Wikipedia).
- ☐ **Diesel trucks**
  From 1982, 6.2 diesel trucks got their own fender and tailgate badging (Wikipedia). Diesels needed the B3J diesel equipment package per the 1982 spec sheet.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/chevrolet/suburban-square/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks